

Hackles Mentors • Screening and Background Checks

The Hackles Kit

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FIELD NOTE

No. 1

Status: DRAFT. Screening rules for people who work with minors depend on state law, school district policy, the host's own rules and the college's minors-contact policy. Everything here is a framework for your HR office and counsel to adapt. [COUNSEL/HR TO CONFIRM] Nothing here is legal advice. No mentor contacts any child before every step is complete.

01 Principles

1. **The strictest applicable rule governs.** If the school, district, state or college requires more than this document, follow that.
2. **Screening is a process, and a check is one part of it.** Applications, an interview, references, training and ongoing supervision all matter. A clean record does not mean a safe person.
3. **Fair and consistent.** Apply the same steps to every applicant. Follow fair-chance and consumer-reporting rules [COUNSEL/HR TO CONFIRM; VERIFY federal and state law].
4. **Privacy.** Keep screening records in a locked or access-limited system with a retention period set by HR [LOCAL]. Share results only with people who need them. The impact tracker never contains screening data.

02 Steps

STEP	WHAT	OWNER	NOTES
1	Application (short form): name, contact, major, year, why you want to volunteer, availability, relevant experience, two references (one academic or work, one other adult who is not a relative)	Applicant	No question about disability, family status, immigration status or protected characteristics
2	Interview (15 to 20 minutes, by two people, in person or video): scenario questions in Section 4	Coordinator and advisor	Use the same questions for everyone
3	References (two, by short phone call or form)	Coordinator	Ask: "Would you trust this person with a group of children? Why?" and "Is there anything we should know?"
4	Background check as required by the minors-contact policy and the host school	HR or the vendor chosen by the college [LOCAL]	Section 3
5	Agreement to the code of conduct, mandated-reporter acknowledgment and photo and social-media rules	Applicant	Document 05
6	Training (four hours) with live practice, and the sign-off from the trainer	Trainer	Document 04
7	Host school clearance if the school requires its own (for example, fingerprinting, a district form or a volunteer badge)	Applicant and school	Done before the first event [VERIFY the host's rules]
8	Placement with a Station Lead and a start date	Coordinator	First event is a shadow event with a Station Lead

03 Background checks (framework)

[COUNSEL/HR TO CONFIRM every line.]

CHECK	TYPICAL REQUIREMENT FOR PEOPLE WHO WORK WITH MINORS	NOTES
Identity verification	Government or college photo ID	
National or state criminal history	Name-based or fingerprint-based, depending on the host's rules and state law [VERIFY]	Some districts require fingerprinting for any volunteer who is around students
Sex offender registry	National and state registry search [VERIFY]	
Child abuse and neglect registry	If the state allows access for volunteers [VERIFY]	
College conduct record	Review for relevant history, such as misconduct involving harm to others, according to the college's policy [COUNSEL/HR TO CONFIRM; FERPA and fairness rules apply]	
Renewal	Every [1 to 2] years, or as the school requires, and whenever a mentor is arrested or charged [COUNSEL/HR TO CONFIRM duty to self-report]	

Who pays. Options include the college's student-engagement budget, the school partner, a grant, or the student. Do not make payment a barrier. [LOCAL decision; HR TO CONFIRM]

Consent and process. The applicant gives written consent for any check. If a check shows something that could disqualify the applicant, the college follows its adverse-action process, including written notice and a chance to respond, as required by law and policy [COUNSEL/HR TO CONFIRM; VERIFY FCRA and state fair-chance requirements].

Status of mentors. Whether a mentor is a volunteer, a student worker, an intern or a service-learning participant affects workers' compensation, minimum wage and liability rules [COUNSEL/HR TO CONFIRM]. Record the status for each mentor.

04 Interview questions (scored by a common rubric, 0 to 2 each)

1. Tell us about a time you worked with children or teens, or helped a younger person learn something.
2. A child at your station quietly says, "My cousin online asked me to keep a secret." What do you do in the first minute? (Look for: stay calm, thank them, do not promise secrecy, tell the staff member present.)
3. A fourth grader asks for your phone number so you can answer their question later. What do you say? (Look for: friendly no, point to the teacher.)
4. The teacher steps out for two minutes and you are alone in the room with six children. What do you do? (Look for: go with the children to find the teacher or bring in another adult; do not stay alone.)
5. A child hugs you. How do you handle it? (Look for: a high-five or wave alternative; follow the school's policy; do not shame the child.)
6. How would you feel about helping children even if you cannot post about it?
7. What questions do you have about our rules?

Concerns that pause an application: reluctance to follow the rules, wanting private contact with children, evasive references, or a disrespectful attitude to the boundaries. Pause and consult the advisor.

05 Decision and records

- The coordinator and advisor decide together, using the rubric, references, check results and training sign-off.
- Applicants get a plain-language answer. A decision not to place is not a judgment of character. Offer other roles, such as materials, art, planning or data tally, which do not involve contact with children.
- Keep: application, rubric, references, consent form, check results (by HR or the vendor), agreement, training sign-off and placement record. Keep out of the tracker.

06 Ongoing monitoring

- A Station Lead observes every new mentor at the first event and signs off.
- Mentors submit an end-of-event check-in (Document 06, Form E).
- Refresher training every [semester or year].
- Any breach, concern or complaint is reported immediately using Document 06.
- Renewal checks are done on schedule.

07 Checklist for the coordinator

- ☐ Application received and reviewed
- ☐ Interview done by two people
- ☐ Two references completed
- ☐ Consent form signed and background checks requested
- ☐ Check results reviewed by HR [COUNSEL/HR TO CONFIRM]
- ☐ Host school clearance complete [if required]
- ☐ Code of conduct signed
- ☐ Training attended and signed off
- ☐ Placement and Station Lead assigned
- ☐ First event shadowed
- ☐ Renewal date set

Hackles has not been evaluated in a controlled study. This is a framework and does not replace the advice of counsel or HR.